

ratios in their batches, B-schools have adopted a multi-pronged strategy in the past 10-12 years with reasonable success. "In IIM Calcutta and other leading IIMs, there used to be only 8-10 per cent women in their MBA class before 2010. In the past decade, that has steadily increased to 30-33 per cent and in some IIMs it has crossed 40 per cent. Among the top schools, ISB has been consistently doing the best in the recent years with gender ratio hovering around 50 per cent. Some of these schools have also developed specific programmes for women executives and women members of the business families," he says.

everything they do is in the public domain. They need to be cautious so that nobody can turn up tomorrow and say they are using discriminatory processes or accuse them of favouritism." Lower-ranked schools, he says, "latch on to diversity brownie points", since most rankings have diversity as one of the important benchmarks, and quality of the students count for little. They are not subjected to public scrutiny unlike the IIMs. Perhaps this explains why some lower-ranked schools have great diversity rankings. "The supply chain is critical to accelerate gender diversity across the board. If more women are getting into good undergraduate col-

Most B-school professors say that the 'CAT-bias' in admissions to top B-schools is the reason for the skewed gender ratio at the institutes, and it needs to be tackled vigorously

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Ray believes that having more women in the faculty and academic leadership roles make a significant difference. "B-schools are encouraging more women faculty and leaders. Seeing is believing. Women students will have more role models. When you talk of leadership roles in the corporates, there used to be only one woman out of 10 potential candidates in the pool. Naturally, the odds of getting up the ladder used to be stacked heavily against her," he says. "If corporates don't get a pool of more MBA women, they'll have a problem of diversity in the leadership roles. It's the whole chain that we need to break and fast."

JAKHAR AGREES THAT having a woman director and faculty helps. "In the past three to four years, more than 50 per cent of the new hires were women. For IIM Lucknow, our Director is a woman and she is very proactive about this. In our entrance [exam] and interviews, sometimes we give women extra weightage and we're trying to have more women's representation. The India story would be incomplete if we don't have women's representation," he says.

The historical challenge for top B-schools, according to Ray, has been to maintain the quality of students on parameters like quantitative skills and mathematical reasoning while promoting gender diversity. "Maintaining that balance between the narrowly defined notion of quality and gender diversity has been a challenge. Besides, particularly for IIMs,

leges and willing to pursue professional careers, there will be no compromise on quality of intake in whatsoever way it is defined. That will eventually be reflected in the consistency of gender-diverse and quality students in our MBA schools," he says.

Bharat Bhasker, Director of IIM Ahmedabad, too, doesn't believe quotas or special promotion for women would help their case, but he does agree that there are other ways to improve gender diversity in B-schools, such as encouraging women to be a part of the interview pool and having a diverse range of subjects. "We used to get 90 per cent of our class from engineering backgrounds, and there was a lack of diversity because the pipeline itself had a large number of engineers, who were mostly males. We have diversified our subjects; we don't want most students in our classes to be engineers. You need to have a variety of people—from arts, commerce, design, fashion technology, etc.," he says. "By improving the subject diversity, we've indirectly encouraged women. The next step is to create a specific executive education programme for women where we train them with management capabilities, and in order to subsidise that, we've tied up with corporates where 75 per cent of the fees will be paid by them," he explains.

After all, it's a cultural issue, he says. "We have to move away from the perception that women are only good for softer courses. It will take another generation to reach that goal." **BT**

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